

Dustlight Crossing

Jungle Chess — astronomical observation theme: rival sky projections cross dust lanes to replace the other observatory's reference image.

For two players. This set preserves the specific [Leiden Dou Shou Qi](#) rules, including mutual Rat–Elephant capture. The celestial contrast ranks are fiction, not measurements of real brightness or mass.

1 / Set up

Join the four panels into a rectangle with seven columns and nine rows. Each player takes eight pieces. **Circular bases are White and move first; clipped-square bases are Black.** Ownership is identifiable by shape as well as color.

View the board from White's edge: columns **a–g** run left to right, rows **1–9** run near to far. Place the pieces as follows; their rank numerals identify them without knowing the astronomy names.

BLACK · CLIPPED-SQUARE BASES

9							
8							
7							
6							
5							
4							
3							
2							
1							
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g

WHITE · CIRCULAR BASES · FIRST MOVE

Rank	Source role	Celestial form
1	Rat	Dust knot
2	Cat	Asteroid
3	Wolf	Crater moon
4	Dog	Ringed planet
5	Panther	Red dwarf
6	Tiger	Twin-tail comet
7	Lion	Pulsar
8	Elephant	Red giant

Two **water / dust-lane** rectangles occupy columns b–c and e–f, each in rows 4–6. Their square boundaries still count individually. White's **den / reference aperture** is d1, protected by **traps / cancellation masks** c1,d2,e1. Black's den is d9, with traps c9,d8,e9. All other spaces are ordinary land / clear fields. Long separated strokes mark water cells, four short bars mark traps, and a closed frame marks each den; the circle and square border marks identify the nearby den owner. Every piece and position is visible; there are no dice or cards.

2 / Play and finish

Alternate turns. Move exactly one of your pieces **one square horizontally or vertically**. Never move diagonally, pass, leave the board, land on a friendly piece, or enter your own den. Use an empty legal square or capture a rival there, replacing it and removing it from play.

Capture: your rank must equal or exceed the rival's rank. The exception is Rat1, which may also capture Elephant8. **Elephant8 may capture Rat1 too.** Wolf is3 and Dog is4 in this version.

Water: only Rat1 may enter or occupy water. Rats step through it normally and may capture each other within water or across either side of a water/land boundary. A Rat starting in water cannot capture an Elephant on land; it must start on land for that capture. Other pieces cannot enter water even to capture a Rat.

Jump: Tiger6 and Lion7 may leap horizontally or vertically from land beside water, across the entire water section, onto the first land square beyond. They cannot leap if **either team's Rat occupies any intervening water square**. The landing square must be empty or contain a rival they can normally capture. They cannot stop in water, leap diagonally, skip land squares, or jump land pieces.

Traps: a piece standing in an opponent's trap has rank0 and any defending piece can capture it. Its rank returns when it leaves, so it can capture normally while moving out. Your own traps do not weaken your pieces. A trap changes neither movement nor water access.

End the game

Win immediately by placing any piece in the opponent's den, or by capturing the opponent's last piece. If the player to move still has pieces but has no legal move, the result is a **stalemate draw**. The same arrangement occurring three times, with the same player to move, is also a **draw**. Remember earlier positions together or jot them down when a cycle begins. There is no extra move limit, points score or tiebreak.

Inventory and replacements

Inventory: four board panels and sixteen pieces, one of each rank per team. There are no promotions or extra-piece requirements. If a piece is lost, substitute a clearly marked piece of the same team and rank or reprint it; a shortage never changes legal choices.

Rule source

Original rule wording and sculptural expression; traditional Dou Shou Qi lineage, no affiliation with Leiden or any commercial edition. Source setup is independently documented in [Leiden's initializer](#). This is a digital design; physical printing and handling have not been tested.

3 / Read the sky

The board is a fictional viewing mosaic shared by two observatories; all mechanics above remain Jungle Chess.

Rule	One-sentence meaning
Setup and teams	Two visible sky projections start from opposing calibrated reference positions.
First move and turns	The circular observatory takes the first exposure and the two observatories then alternate.
Orthogonal step	Each exposure shifts one image to a neighboring mosaic field.
Ranked capture	An image erases an equal-or-lower contrast rival and takes its field.
Rat takes Elephant	A compact Dust knot can occult the broad Red giant image.
Elephant takes Rat	The Red giant's glare can wash out a Dust knot image.
Swimming	Only a Dust knot remains a distinct silhouette inside the obscuring dust lanes.
Rat boundary capture	A sharper dust silhouette can replace another on either side of a lane boundary.
No water Rat–Elephant capture	A knot immersed in the lane cannot project the isolated silhouette needed to occult the Giant.
Jumping	The Comet's trail and Pulsar's beam reconnect their images across an uninterrupted dust lane.
Jump blocking	Any distinct dust knot breaks that straight connecting trace.
Jump capture	A reconnected trace erases its landing rival only when its contrast rank allows.
Opponent trap	The opposing cancellation mask suppresses an intruding image's contrast to zero.
Own trap	An observatory's mask preserves its own images.
Leaving a trap	Leaving the cancellation field restores normal contrast.
Own den forbidden	Your reference aperture is your projection's source, not its destination.
Den victory	Reaching the rival reference aperture replaces its projection and wins.
Elimination victory	Erasing all rival images leaves your projection uncontested.
Stalemate	If the next exposure cannot shift a surviving image, neither projection takes the mosaic.
Threefold repetition	A third identical arrangement establishes an unresolved repeating view.